

ANCIENT EGYPTIAN WEAPONRY

Egyptian soldiers were mainly peasant conscripts who fought almost exclusively on foot until around 1500BCE. The archers were the most important component of the army, and they carried light bows with a range of about 50m (165ft). The other infantry, known as the *nakhtu-aa* ("strong-armed"), fought in close formation using battle-axes and spears. Both types of warrior also carried a dagger in a leather scabbard, which was often strapped to the lower arm. For protection, the archers relied on a leather kilt, while the infantry carried a large, wooden-framed shield covered with cowhide. After the beginning of the New Kingdom in around 1550BCE, the Egyptian army began to use chariots, which were utilized by archers as a mobile platform from which to fire.



▲ FLINT ARROWHEAD

Date 5500–3100BCE

Origin Egypt

Weight 2–2.5g (1/40z)

Length 6.1cm (2 1/4in)

Archers formed a crucial component of Egyptian armies. They carried a simple bow, around 1.5m (5ft) long, made of acacia wood. The arrowheads were made of bone, flint, ebony, or copper, with triangular or barbed ends.

Hole for
threading
rawhide lashing

Triangular end for
cutting into flesh

◀ BRONZE AXEHEAD

Date 2055–1650BCE

Origin Egypt

Length 17.1cm (6 3/4in)

Broad, round-headed axes were popular in the Middle Kingdom (2055–1650BCE). This broad, scalloped axehead was called an epsilon, due to the shape made by its three tangs, that was similar to the Greek letter. The shape of the head allowed a wide slashing action, most effective against opponents with minimal armour.

Wide half-moon
shaped head

▼ BRONZE SPEARHEAD

Date c.2000BCE

Origin Egypt

Length 25cm (10in)

Egyptian infantrymen were usually equipped with a spear, which was generally used for thrusting rather than throwing. Before around 1500BCE, the blade was lashed to the haft rather than inserted into a socket.



Fine linen cloth
covering blade



Bronze axehead

Rawhide binding

▲ BATTLE-AXE

Date 1630–1520BCE

Origin Egypt

Length 41.1cm (16 1/4in)

Egyptian axes typically had a heavy, bronze, D-shaped head. This axehead was attached to the haft with wet rawhide thongs to ensure a stronger fit. The hafts were generally wider at the base, which was wrapped in linen to provide a stronger grip.



Gilded hilt

Corroded blade

▼ LONG SWORD

Date 1539–1075BCE

Origin Egypt

Length 40.6cm (16in)

This double-edged copper sword, worn on a belt around the soldier's waist, dates from the New Kingdom. Its straight blade made it more suitable for thrusting than slashing. The gold hilt suggests it was crafted for an elite warrior.

Falcon on the
underside of the pommel

